

media, and the internet are merely the latest mediums of choice.

That's not to say that all of the mediums are the same, because they're definitely not. Over the years, targeting has gotten better, and reach has increased. Although in India we're still very far from being able to reach all our citizens using the internet, in more developed countries, that number is fast approaching 100 per cent.

SO WHO ARE "THEY"?

As we said before: Every. Single. Company. Without exception, if you have signed up for a service, any service, it is immediately now a part of the set "They". Even a VPN service that you use to try and hide your identity is part of "they" because even they use your data. How? Imagine if India suddenly started prosecuting piracy, and thousands were being fined heavily, do you think it would stop piracy, or result in more VPN sales? Now, if you were in the VPN business, and suddenly you saw a lot of people in India starting to sign up for paid VPN services, don't you think you would use that data to start advertising your services more in India? Thus, you or me signing up for a service makes us a data point, and no company is ignoring those data points any more. None. Not even us. Thus, "they" is literally everyone!

WHAT DO THEY KNOW?

And very quickly we get to the meat of this article, because it is what most of us are curious about. As I said at the start of this article, I will use myself as the example, and you might have far, far more data out there, or much less, depending on how many services you use. In all honesty, I'm not going to be able to cover all of the services who have data on me, merely the more obvious ones with larger data sets.

1. Facebook

As a regular user, most of my data is probably accessible via Facebook. Everything I've shared on there, I shared intentionally with people who are my "friends". That's in quotes because I have far, far more people on my friend list who I have never met, than actual friends. Many of you might also be on

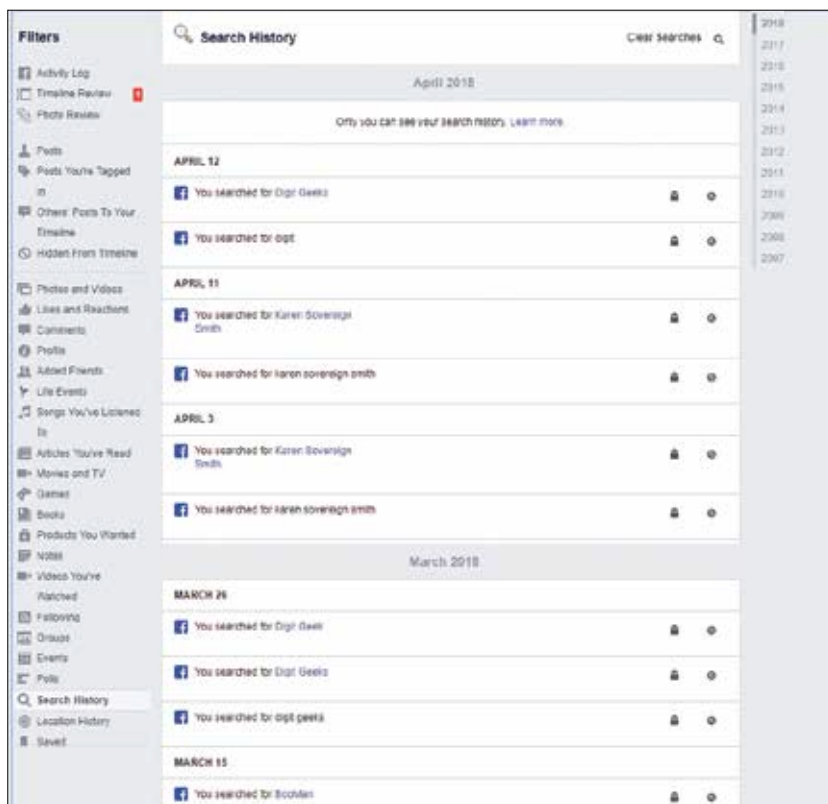
my list, and although we have a relationship that's very special to me, let's face it, we're not friends.

So what exactly does Facebook store about me that is not shared, and was not meant to be shared by me?

For one thing, you could check out my search history. Am I stalking ex girlfriends? Part of any hate groups? On the desktop, just click in the search bar, and when Recent Searches pop up, look for the Edit button. Mine's pretty boring. Sadly.

Next, you would probably want to head over to *Download all my data*.

email address, my office phone number, and perhaps other data about me. In contrast, say, a school friend might store my mobile number, personal email, birthday, address, and more personal information about me. Both you and he use Facebook, and give access to your contacts, and it sees an entry with the same name, and some common information, clearly suggesting that I am the same person, and without me even having a Facebook profile, it still has data about me. Later, when I sign up for the service, I find that Facebook is recommend-



Apparently I stalk my wife... a lot! And also Booman...

This would give you a stripped down archive of a lot of the activity logs and data Facebook has.

The first thing you will notice is that if you have the Facebook app on your phone, it already has a copy of your entire phonebook under Contact Info. This is partly the information that's used for the so called "shadow profiles" that have now become common knowledge, even if Facebook denies their existence.

This is how it works. Let's say you have my contact information in your phone book. You have my official

ing both you and my school friend as people I may know, and I'm amazed at how wonderful Facebook is. And it's not just people who aren't on Facebook yet, there are supposedly shadow profiles for even existing users. So if I'm trying to keep work and personal life separate, Facebook might not care, and start recommending my profile to work colleagues, and vice versa, and privacy is lost.

That's not all the data that Facebook has though. If you go to *Settings > Ads > Advertisers*, you will see a rather large list of advertisers who have your